

Common Medications Guide

Understanding Your Medications

This guide provides information about commonly prescribed medications. Always follow your healthcare provider's instructions and read the medication label carefully.

Pain Relief Medications

Acetaminophen (Tylenol)

Uses:

- Pain relief (headaches, muscle aches, arthritis)
- Fever reduction

Dosage:

- Adults: 325-650 mg every 4-6 hours
- Maximum: 3,000-4,000 mg per day
- Children: Based on weight (consult pediatrician)

Important Information:

- Does not reduce inflammation
- Safer for stomach than NSAIDs
- Risk of liver damage with excessive use or alcohol
- Check other medications for acetaminophen content

Side Effects:

- Generally well-tolerated
- Rare: Allergic reactions, liver problems

Ibuprofen (Advil, Motrin)

Uses:

- Pain relief
- Inflammation reduction
- Fever reduction

Dosage:

- Adults: 200-400 mg every 4-6 hours
- Maximum: 1,200 mg per day (OTC), 3,200 mg (prescription)

Important Information:

- Take with food to reduce stomach upset
- Avoid if history of stomach ulcers
- May increase blood pressure
- Can affect kidney function with long-term use

Side Effects:

- Stomach upset, heartburn
- Dizziness
- Increased bleeding risk

Aspirin

Uses:

- Pain relief
- Fever reduction
- Heart attack/stroke prevention (low dose)
- Anti-inflammatory

Dosage:

- Pain: 325-650 mg every 4 hours
- Heart protection: 81-325 mg daily
- Maximum: 4,000 mg per day

Important Information:

- Take with food
- Increases bleeding risk
- Not for children with viral infections (Reye's syndrome risk)
- Consult doctor before stopping if taking for heart protection

Side Effects:

- Stomach irritation
- Increased bleeding
- Ringing in ears (high doses)

Cardiovascular Medications

Statins (Atorvastatin, Simvastatin)

Uses:

- Lower cholesterol
- Reduce heart attack and stroke risk

Common Brands:

- Lipitor (atorvastatin)
- Zocor (simvastatin)
- Crestor (rosuvastatin)

Dosage:

- Varies by medication and cholesterol levels
- Usually taken once daily in evening

Important Information:

- Avoid grapefruit juice (interferes with some statins)
- Regular liver function tests needed
- Report muscle pain or weakness immediately
- Continue healthy diet and exercise

Side Effects:

- Muscle aches
- Digestive problems
- Increased blood sugar
- Liver enzyme elevation

ACE Inhibitors (Lisinopril, Enalapril)

Uses:

- High blood pressure
- Heart failure
- Kidney protection in diabetes

Common Brands:

- Prinivil, Zestril (lisinopril)
- Vasotec (enalapril)

Dosage:

- Starting: 5-10 mg daily
- Maintenance: 10-40 mg daily

Important Information:

- May cause persistent dry cough
- Avoid potassium supplements
- Not safe during pregnancy
- Monitor kidney function and potassium levels

Side Effects:

- Dry cough (10-20% of patients)
- Dizziness
- Elevated potassium
- Angioedema (rare but serious)

Beta Blockers (Metoprolol, Atenolol)

Uses:

- High blood pressure
- Heart failure
- Irregular heartbeat
- Angina
- Migraine prevention

Common Brands:

- Lopressor, Toprol (metoprolol)
- Tenormin (atenolol)

Important Information:

- Don't stop suddenly (can worsen heart condition)
- May mask low blood sugar symptoms in diabetics
- Can cause fatigue
- May worsen asthma

Side Effects:

- Fatigue
- Cold hands and feet
- Slow heart rate
- Dizziness

Diabetes Medications

Metformin (Glucophage)

Uses:

- Type 2 diabetes
- Prediabetes
- Polycystic ovary syndrome (PCOS)

Dosage:

- Starting: 500 mg once or twice daily
- Maintenance: 1,000-2,000 mg daily (divided doses)
- Maximum: 2,550 mg daily

Important Information:

- Take with meals to reduce stomach upset
- Start with low dose and increase gradually
- Stop before surgery or imaging with contrast dye
- Most effective with diet and exercise

Side Effects:

- Diarrhea, nausea (usually temporary)
- Metallic taste
- Vitamin B12 deficiency (long-term use)
- Lactic acidosis (rare but serious)

Insulin

Types:

- **Rapid-acting:** Starts in 15 minutes (Humalog, Novolog)
- **Short-acting:** Starts in 30 minutes (Regular insulin)
- **Intermediate-acting:** Starts in 1-2 hours (NPH)
- **Long-acting:** Lasts 24 hours (Lantus, Levemir)

Important Information:

- Store unopened insulin in refrigerator
- In-use insulin can be kept at room temperature (28 days)
- Rotate injection sites
- Check expiration dates
- Never freeze insulin

Side Effects:

- Low blood sugar (hypoglycemia)
- Weight gain
- Injection site reactions

- Lipodystrophy
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Respiratory Medications

Albuterol (ProAir, Ventolin)

Uses:

- Asthma
- COPD
- Exercise-induced bronchospasm

Dosage:

- 2 puffs every 4-6 hours as needed
- Before exercise: 2 puffs 15-30 minutes prior

Important Information:

- Rescue inhaler (quick relief)
- Shake well before use
- Rinse mouth after use
- Track number of uses
- Seek medical attention if using more frequently

Side Effects:

- Rapid heartbeat
- Tremor
- Nervousness
- Headache

Inhaled Corticosteroids (Fluticasone)

Uses:

- Asthma control
- COPD management

Common Brands:

- Flovent
- Advair (combination with long-acting beta agonist)

Important Information:

- Controller medication (not for quick relief)

- Use daily even when feeling well
- Rinse mouth after each use to prevent thrush
- May take weeks to see full benefit

Side Effects:

- Oral thrush
 - Hoarse voice
 - Cough
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Gastrointestinal Medications

Proton Pump Inhibitors (Omeprazole, Pantoprazole)

Uses:

- GERD (acid reflux)
- Stomach ulcers
- Erosive esophagitis

Common Brands:

- Prilosec (omeprazole)
- Protonix (pantoprazole)
- Nexium (esomeprazole)

Dosage:

- 20-40 mg once daily
- Take 30-60 minutes before first meal

Important Information:

- Not for immediate heartburn relief
- Use lowest effective dose for shortest duration
- May reduce absorption of certain nutrients
- Increased infection risk with long-term use

Side Effects:

- Headache
 - Diarrhea or constipation
 - Nausea
 - Vitamin B12 deficiency (long-term)
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Antibiotics

Amoxicillin

Uses:

- Bacterial infections (ear, throat, skin, urinary tract)

Dosage:

- Adults: 250-500 mg every 8 hours or 500-875 mg every 12 hours
- Children: Based on weight

Important Information:

- Complete full course even if feeling better
- Take with or without food
- Report rash immediately (may indicate allergy)
- May reduce effectiveness of birth control pills

Side Effects:

- Diarrhea
- Nausea
- Rash
- Yeast infections

Azithromycin (Z-Pack)

Uses:

- Respiratory infections
- Skin infections
- Sexually transmitted infections

Dosage:

- Typical: 500 mg day 1, then 250 mg days 2-5

Important Information:

- Can be taken with or without food
- Complete full course
- May cause irregular heartbeat in susceptible individuals

Side Effects:

- Diarrhea

- Nausea
 - Abdominal pain
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Antidepressants

SSRIs (Sertraline, Fluoxetine)

Uses:

- Depression
- Anxiety disorders
- OCD
- PTSD

Common Brands:

- Zoloft (sertraline)
- Prozac (fluoxetine)
- Lexapro (escitalopram)

Dosage:

- Starting: 25-50 mg daily
- Maintenance: 50-200 mg daily

Important Information:

- Takes 4-6 weeks for full effect
- Don't stop suddenly (taper gradually)
- May initially increase anxiety
- Monitor for worsening depression or suicidal thoughts

Side Effects:

- Nausea (usually temporary)
 - Sexual dysfunction
 - Weight changes
 - Insomnia or drowsiness
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Medication Safety Tips

General Guidelines

1. Taking Medications Properly

- Follow prescribed dosage and schedule
- Don't skip doses
- Don't double up if you miss a dose
- Take with or without food as directed
- Use measuring devices for liquids (not household spoons)

2. Storage

- Keep in original containers
- Store in cool, dry place (unless refrigeration required)
- Keep away from children and pets
- Check expiration dates regularly
- Don't store in bathroom (humidity affects medications)

3. Drug Interactions

- Inform all healthcare providers of all medications
- Include over-the-counter drugs and supplements
- Ask pharmacist about interactions
- Avoid alcohol unless approved by doctor
- Be cautious with grapefruit juice

4. Side Effects

- Know common side effects
- Report severe or persistent side effects
- Don't stop medications without consulting doctor
- Keep emergency contact information handy

When to Call Your Doctor

- Severe allergic reaction (difficulty breathing, swelling, severe rash)
- Unexpected or severe side effects
- Medication not working as expected
- Questions about dosage or timing
- Need refills
- Considering over-the-counter medications or supplements

Medication List Template

Keep an updated list including:

- Medication name (brand and generic)
- Dosage and strength
- Frequency and timing
- Prescribing doctor
- Reason for taking

- Pharmacy information
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Important Reminders

⚠ **Medical Disclaimer:** This guide is for educational purposes only. Always consult your healthcare provider or pharmacist for personalized medication advice.

☐ **Poison Control:** 1-800-222-1222 (available 24/7)

☐ **Medication Disposal:** Use drug take-back programs or follow FDA guidelines for safe disposal.

☐ **Never Share:** Don't share prescription medications with others, even if they have similar symptoms.

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